The ABCC Competition Handbook — 2027 Edition

Asper Business Case Competition (ABCC), 5th Annual — February 18–22, 2027, Winnipeg, Canada

Prepared for the competing team and coaching staff. Status: the 2027 day-by-day schedule and case sponsors are still "TBA" on the official page. Wherever a 2027 detail is unconfirmed, this handbook says so explicitly and states the most recent verified baseline (the official 2025 Competition Guide — the fullest public rulebook — plus documented 2026 practice). Treat the 2027 Competition Guide, when it is emailed to teams, as the final authority.

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1. What the ABCC Is

The Asper Business Case Competition is a national (and, since 2026, internationalizing) graduate-level case competition hosted by the I.H. Asper School of Business and the Stu Clark Graduate School at the University of Manitoba in Winnipeg. Nine teams of four Master's/MBA students compete over three competition days in three rounds with three genuinely different case formats — a two-week **prepared case**, a four-hour **boardroom case**, and a three-hour **traditional case** — followed by a public **final round** for the top three teams. Every case is a live engagement written for a real client organization; roughly 50 industry judges, drawn heavily from The Associates (a network of ~370 Manitoba business executives), evaluate the teams, and the winning recommendations are handed to the client companies afterwards.

Two features distinguish the ABCC from most comparable competitions (e.g., the John Molson MBA ICC, which enforces hard no-internet sequestration): the ABCC **explicitly allows internet access — including password-protected databases, file sharing, and generative AI — during timed prep**, and it stakes 45% of the score on the final short-prep round. Preparation should be built around both facts.

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2. History and Positioning

The competition launched in February 2023 as the **Asper Leadership Case Competition (ALCC)** — billed as the first national graduate case competition hosted by Asper — with two rounds weighted 50/50 and eight Canadian teams, all working Manitoba Hydro cases. In 2024 it was renamed the ABCC, expanded to nine teams, and adopted its current three-round, 25/30/45 format, adding the signature boardroom round.

Year	Edition	Dates	Format	Field	Champion
2023	ALCC (1st)	Feb 23–25	2 rounds, 50/50 + finals	8 (Canadian)	Not published (Asper 2nd)

Year	Edition	Dates	Format	Field	Champion
2024	ABCC (2nd)	Feb 21–24	3 rounds, 25/30/45 + finals	9	Asper (“Stellaris Consulting”)
2025	ABCC (3rd)	Feb 19–23	3 rounds, 25/30/45 + finals	9 (Ivey, Memorial debut)	Memorial University
2026	ABCC (4th)	Feb 18–21 (+dep. 22)	3 rounds, 25/30/45 + finals	9, first international team	Babeș-Bolyai University (Romania)
2027	ABCC (5th)	Feb 18–22	Same format announced	TBA	—

Recent fields have included Asper (host), Beedie (SFU), DeGroote (McMaster), HEC Montréal, Ivey (Western), John Molson (Concordia), Levene (Regina), Memorial, Telfer (Ottawa), Haskayne (Calgary), Rotman, and Ted Rogers (TMU). The 2026 edition drew 100+ people: 35 competitors, 9 faculty advisors, ~50 industry judges, and 52 volunteers. Babeș-Bolyai’s 2026 title — winning all three qualifying rounds plus the final, and taking home CAD 5,000 and the trophy — established that a well-drilled non-Canadian team can win this event outright. Recent case clients: Jazz Winnipeg, Coal & Canary, Access Credit Union (2026); Manitoba Museum, AROW Global, People Corporation (2025); WAG-Qaumajuq, Independent Jewellers, StandardAero (2024). Expect one non-profit/arts client, one mid-size Manitoba manufacturer/consumer firm, and one financial-services or services firm — always with a Manitoba anchor.

Key people: **Judith (Judy) Jayasuriya**, Instructor and Lead, Experiential Learning (competition lead since inception); **Steven Harrison**, Case Competition Coordinator and on-site primary contact (2025 cell: 204-396-9631). General contact: **aspercasecomps@umanitoba.ca**. Live updates run on Instagram **@asper_bcc**.

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3. Eligibility, Entry, and Registration

- **Entry is by school, not by open sign-up.** Asper invites/hosts graduate teams from business schools; there is no public registration portal or published entry fee anywhere in the official materials — the event is sponsor-financed (tiers from $1,000 Room Sponsor to $25,000 Diamond; case sponsorship is $10,000). Participation logistics are coordinated between each school and the organizers via aspercasecomps@umanitoba.ca.
- **Team composition:** exactly **4 students** plus a faculty advisor/coach. Eligible members are full-time, part-time, or executive MBA students, **and Master’s-level students of other management programs** — so a mixed MSc team qualifies. (The official boilerplate says “top Canadian business schools,” but the 2026 invitation of Babeș-Bolyai from Romania is precedent that international teams compete by arrangement with the organizers.)
- **School-side selection** is each school’s own affair (Asper runs credit courses and tryouts; HEC Montréal selects via its competitions service). There is no first-time-only rule published for the ABCC (unlike JMICC).
- **On-site registration:** teams register in person on arrival evening — 2025 baseline: **5:00 p.m., team registration and division draw**, followed by free time (arrival-night dinner is *not* provided). The draw assigns each team a letter **A–I**, forming **three pools of three**, which determines presentation slots for the whole week (see §6 and §11).
- **2027 venue:** the Drake Centre — which *is* the Asper School of Business building (181 Freedman Crescent); the official page’s per-day listings all point there, and the daily agenda is TBA. In 2024–25 the prepared-case day was staged at the client’s own site (Winnipeg Art Gallery, Manitoba Museum); whether 2027 adds a client-site day is TBA.

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4. The Event Flow: Arrival to Gala

The 2027 day-by-day schedule is TBA. The structure below is the verified 2025 template (dates shifted), which 2026 followed with minor variations; 2027 runs February 18–22, which by the calendar is a Thursday–Monday footprint (prior editions ran Wednesday–Sunday) — confirm exact day allocation when the 2027 guide arrives.

Day	Content (2025 actuals as baseline)
Day 0 (arrival)	Teams arrive; prepared-case decks already submitted by **10:00 a.m. CT** that morning; 5:00 p.m. registration + division draw; evening free (own dinner).
Day 1 — Round 1 (Prepared)	Breakfast 7:00–8:30; presentations from 9:30 a.m. in three slot waves; competitor lunch ~12:00; **judges’ feedback sessions** 12:50–1:35 p.m. (15-minute blocks per team); afternoon social (The Forks); evening event (2025: Manitoba Museum reception).

Day	Content (2025 actuals as baseline)
Day 2 — Round 2 (Boardroom)	Staggered 4-hour preps from 9:30 a.m.; lunch delivered during prep; presentations from 2:00 p.m.; feedback 4:30–5:15; evening at **Festival du Voyageur**.
Day 3 — Round 3 (Traditional) + Finals + Gala	Staggered 3-hour preps from 8:40 a.m.; presentations from 12:00; lunch in prep rooms; feedback ~2:40–3:10; **finalist announcement ~3:50 p.m.; public finals 4:20/5:00/5:40; reception 6:45; awards dinner 7:15 (Marshall McLuhan Hall); student mixer 10:00 p.m.**
Day 4 (departure)	Teams depart.

Transfers between the official venues are organized by the committee and run to the slot times above.

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5. The Three Rounds in Forensic Detail

All rounds share these constants: everything is **in English**; decks are **PowerPoint (.pptx) only** (Prezi and similar prohibited); slide **templates may be built in advance** by the team (third-party/purchased templates prohibited for the prepared case); **every team member must speak** in every round; a **timekeeper shows a yellow card at 5 minutes remaining and a red card at 1 minute remaining** in each timed segment (exception noted below); slide clickers are provided; late-arriving teams get no extra prep or presentation time; organizers accept no responsibility for technical problems; and all decks are shared with the case-sponsor companies after the event.

5.1 Round 1 — Prepared Case (25%)

- **Release:** emailed roughly two weeks out (2025: released Feb 5 for a Feb 20 presentation).
- **Hand-in:** the final deck is due **by email to aspercasecomps@umanitoba.ca at 10:00 a.m. Central Time on arrival day** (2025 baseline), file named **"[Team Name] Prepared Case"**. A late deck drops the team to **the bottom of its pool** for this round — a severe, quasi-automatic penalty.
- **Format:** stand-up presentation, **25 minutes**, followed by **15 minutes of Q&A**; card warnings in both segments; unlimited slides and exhibits.
- **Rules during prep:** everything is allowed — course materials, faculty and coach input, external research, any resources — **except contacting employees of the case-sponsor organization**. This is the round where your professor/coach can and should be fully involved.
- **Judge interaction:** classic panel format; questions come after the presentation. A 15-minute per-team feedback session follows later the same day — attend it; it calibrates you for the heavier rounds.

5.2 Round 2 — Boardroom Case (30%)

The ABCC's signature round; it simulates presenting to an executive board rather than at one.

- **Release and prep:** the case is released **staggered by presentation slot**; teams get **exactly 4 hours** in an assigned prep room. From the moment of release: no contact with coaches or anyone outside the team.
- **Hand-in:** within the 4-hour window, the team saves to an **organizer-provided USB stick**: the deck **plus a one-page executive summary**, file named **"[Team Name] Boardroom Case"**. The executive summary doubles as the judge-facing one-page black-and-white brief.
- **Format:** the team is **seated at a boardroom table across from the judges** (2026: four judges plus a representative of the client company). The presentation has two phases:
  1. **3 uninterrupted minutes** pitching from **one single executive-summary slide** — no appendix access; a red card comes at 1 minute remaining.
  2. A **22-minute open discussion** with the judges, during which the summary slide **and unlimited appendix slides** may be used; 5-minute and 1-minute warnings apply; a **mouse is provided** for non-linear navigation.
- **Speaking rule:** every member must speak at some point in the discussion — not necessarily in the protected 3 minutes.
- **Devices:** one laptop per student (max 4); **no cellphones, smart watches, or other electronics**; internet (including GenAI) is allowed on the laptops; prebuilt templates allowed. Volunteers step into prep rooms periodically to verify compliance.
- **What wins here:** a defensible answer with instantly navigable backup. Build the appendix as a modular evidence library (financials, sizing, implementation, risks) and rehearse jumping to any slide in under five seconds.

5.3 Round 3 — Traditional Case (45%)

The heaviest round — worth nearly half the qualifying score and the deck that finalists must reuse.

- **Release and prep:** staggered by slot; **3 hours** of prep under the same isolation, device, and monitoring rules as the boardroom round.
- **Hand-in:** deck saved to the provided USB within the 3 hours, file named **"[Team Name] Traditional Case"**. No executive summary is required.
- **Format:** stand-up presentation, **20 minutes plus 10 minutes Q&A**, card warnings in both; unlimited slides; every member speaks.

5.4 The Final Round

- **Qualification:** cumulative weighted score across Rounds 1–3 (25/30/45). The **top 3** advance; the finalist announcement comes mid-afternoon on the last competition day.
- **Format:** finalists re-present **the identical traditional-case deck — no changes permitted whatsoever** — to a **brand-new judge panel**, with an extended **20-minute presentation + 15-minute Q&A** (cards in both). Practically, the extra Q&A time is where finals are won: pressure-test the traditional deck immediately after Round 3.
- **Sequestration:** finalists are escorted to a **holding room** until they present, and **faculty advisors of finalist teams may not communicate with their team** until after it has presented. Finals are **public** — all other teams, coaches, and guests watch.
- **Awards:** the finals panel decides placements, announced at the gala with trophy and oversized cheques (1st/2nd/3rd traditionally presented by the Diamond/Platinum/Gold sponsors). Prize money is not published for recent years except the 2026 first prize of **CAD 5,000**; the 2023 scale was $5,000/$3,000/$1,000.

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6. Scoring, Weights, and Tie-Breaks

Component	Weight	Prep time	Presentation format
Round 1 — Prepared	25%	~2 weeks	25 min + 15 min Q&A
Round 2 — Boardroom	30%	4 hours	3 min pitch + 22 min discussion
Round 3 — Traditional	45%	3 hours	20 min + 10 min Q&A
Final (top 3 only)	Determines podium	Frozen deck	20 min + 15 min Q&A

- Judges score each round against the official rubric (§7). The exact point scale and cross-panel normalization are **not published**; the division draw (pools of three rotating through slots) equalizes timing advantages, and the "bottom of pool" late-penalty language indicates within-pool ranking matters.
- **Tie-breaks:** per the 2025 guide, a tie for a finals berth is broken by the **higher traditional-case score**. The current (2026/27-cycle) page text expands this into a cascade — performance in the highest-weighted rounds first, then rubric categories. Assume the cascade applies in 2027.
- Strategic arithmetic: Rounds 2+3 are 75% of qualification and both are short-prep rounds. The prepared case can position you, but the competition is decided under time pressure.

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7. The Judging Rubric (Official, 2025 Guide)

Seven criteria with multipliers, total weight 10.5x. This is the actual scoresheet judges use in every round.

#	Criterion	Multiplier	What judges look for
1	Communicating Effectively	1.0x	Clear, professional, compelling, easy to follow; readable deck
2	Framing the Problem	1.0x	Issues wrapped into a clear, solvable problem statement covering the majority of primary and most secondary issues
3	Analysis	2.0x	Assessment, recommendation, and implementation substantiated by research, logic, and qualitative + quantitative analysis
4	Recommendation	2.0x	Effective, clear, comprehensive, justified; strategic fit with the organization
5	**Implementation & Resources**	**2.5x**	Clear implementation path with appropriate resources, time, and financial considerations

#	Criterion	Multiplier	What judges look for
6	Impact	1.0x	Quantitative and qualitative benefit; alignment with what the organization seeks
7	Measurement, Risks & Mitigation	1.0x	Progress metrics; realistic risks; effective mitigations

Read the weighting: **Implementation is the single heaviest criterion**, and Analysis + Recommendation + Implementation together carry 6.5 of 10.5 points of weight. A brilliant diagnosis with a thin execution plan loses to a solid diagnosis with a costed, timelined, resourced roadmap. Allocate slide time accordingly: every recommendation needs owners, phases, budget, KPIs, and a risk table — even in a 3-hour case.

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8. What Must Be Handed In, and When

Deliverable	Deadline (2025 baseline; 2027 TBA)	Channel	Penalty if late/wrong
Consulting team name (fictional; no school identifiers)	Requested by organizers pre-event (exact process not published)	Via your school's coordination with organizers	Anonymity breach risks DQ
Prepared-case deck (.pptx), "[Team Name] Prepared Case"	**10:00 a.m. CT, arrival day**	Email to aspercase-comps@umanitoba.ca	Bottom of pool for Round 1
Boardroom deck + **one-page executive summary**, "[Team Name] Boardroom Case"	Within the 4-hour prep window	Organizer-provided USB	No extension; present with whatever is saved
Traditional deck, "[Team Name] Traditional Case"	Within the 3-hour prep window	Organizer-provided USB	Same
Finals deck	Nothing new — Round 3 deck frozen	—	Any change is a rule breach

Slide templates may be built before the competition but are not submitted in advance; there is no published requirement to hand in template files (unlike JMICC's template-USB regime). Rosters and dietary needs are coordinated school-to-organizer; expect the 2027 Competition Guide to specify these details.

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9. Code of Conduct, Devices, and Integrity Rules

School anonymity (the cardinal rule). Teams compete under their fictional consulting name. **Identifying your school of origin to a judge at any point — verbally, on slides, on clothing — means disqualification.** Telling fellow competitors or volunteers is permitted. Scrub logos, course references, and city hints from templates and anecdotes; dress is business professional *without* school identification in front of judges.

Case confidentiality. No discussing case details outside the competition; no photocopying or reproducing cases; and **never contact employees of any case-sponsor organization** in any round.

Coach and advisor rules.

- During the prepared-case build, coach input is fully allowed.
- From the moment a timed case is released until the team presents: **no contact with coaches or anyone outside the team**.
- Coaches may watch all teams present, but once inside a presentation room they must stay for all presentations in that room (stepping out only during judge deliberations) and must not communicate with their team until presentations conclude. **Any coach–student communication during a presentation or Q&A triggers immediate disqualification of the team.**
- Faculty advisors of finalist teams may not communicate with their team until after it presents.

Devices and internet. During timed rounds: maximum **4 laptops (one per student)**; **no cellphones, smart watches, or other electronics**; volunteers enter prep rooms periodically to check. Internet is allowed, including login-required sites, university databases, file-sharing, and **generative AI** — build a rehearsed, tool-supported 3-hour operating procedure, because every team has the same arsenal.

Operational discipline. Late teams forfeit the time; technical failures are the team's own risk (bring

backups on the provided USB early, not at minute 239); decks go to sponsors afterwards, so keep them client-presentable.

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10. Social Program

The social calendar is a designed part of the event — attendance is expected and it is where the "forging relationships" ethos of the ABCC lives.

- **Welcome/arrival evening:** registration, division draw, free evening (a Platinum-sponsor-named welcome reception appears in the sponsorship structure).
- **The Forks:** Winnipeg's historic market district; 2026 featured a team scavenger hunt (including a visit to case-client Coal & Canary's store).
- **Evening receptions:** 2025 held an evening event at the Manitoba Museum; formats rotate with the case clients.
- **Festival du Voyageur:** the Round 2 evening traditionally goes to Western Canada's largest winter festival (outdoor).
- **Awards gala:** reception + dinner at **Marshall McLuhan Hall**, with sponsor speeches, client remarks, trophy and cheque presentations — followed by a **student mixer**.
- Daily amenities: breakfasts, competitor lunches, a sponsor-named competitor greenroom and refreshment area, and transfers throughout.

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11. A Day in the Life: The Short-Prep Saturday (Traditional Round + Finals)

Illustrative walkthrough using 2025 actual times, for a team drawn as letter "E" (Slot 1 on traditional day under the rotation: Prepared Slot 2 → Boardroom Slot 3 → Traditional Slot 1 — each pool takes each position exactly once across the week).

7:00 Breakfast in business professional attire; laptops charged, chargers, adapters (Canadian Type A/B plugs, 120 V), and the team's template file checked the night before. **8:15** Travel to the Drake Centre; phones and smart watches surrendered into bags before prep. **8:40** Case release in your assigned prep room — the 3-hour clock starts. A drilled routine matters more than brilliance now: minutes 0–20 individual read and issue capture; 20–40 alignment on problem statement and recommendation thesis; 40–150 parallel workstreams (financial model, market/qualitative analysis, implementation plan, deck production in the prebuilt template); 150–170 integration, rubric check — is Implementation & Resources (2.5x) the strongest section? — and save; final minutes for Q&A brainstorming. Volunteers will drop in unannounced; a boxed lunch arrives around 12:30 for later slots (Slot 1 eats after presenting). **11:40** USB collected — whatever is on it is final. **12:00** Present: 20 minutes standing, yellow card at 5 remaining, red at 1; all four members speak; then 10 minutes of Q&A. **12:40–13:20** Other slots present; you decompress in the greenroom. **14:40–15:10** Fifteen-minute judge feedback session — take notes; if you make finals, these judges' criticisms are your Q&A prep. **15:50** Finalist announcement. If named: escorted to the **holding room**, no advisor contact, deck frozen. **16:20/17:00/17:40** Public finals — same deck, 20 + 15 before a fresh panel, with rivals and ~50 judges watching. **18:45** Reception; **19:15** awards dinner at Marshall McLuhan Hall — podium revealed, trophy and oversized cheques presented. **22:00** Student mixer. **Sunday** departure.

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12. Open Items for 2027 (TBA Tracker)

Confirm these the moment the 2027 Competition Guide is released: **the weekday footprint** — all three ABCC-format editions started on a Wednesday (2024: Feb 21; 2025: Feb 19; 2026: Feb 18), while the published 2027 window of Feb 18–22 falls **Thursday**→**Monday**, the first Thursday start since the format change (`facts_and_rules.md`, "The 2027 weekday question"); the exact day-by-day schedule and which date carries which round; case-sponsor companies (watch the sponsor page and @asper_bcc from autumn — case writing starts around October); prepared-case release date and deck deadline; the 2027 field of schools; prize amounts; whether Round 1 runs at the Drake Centre or a client site (as in 2024–25); and any rule deltas versus 2025 (already-known 2026/27-cycle additions: expanded tie-breaker cascade, boardroom mouse, printed one-page judge brief, finalist-advisor gag).

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13. Sources

Primary (official University of Manitoba / Asper):

- ABCC 2025 Competition Guide (rules, rubric, schedule, slot rotation): https://umanitoba.ca/asper/sites/asper/files/2025-01/abcc25-eventguide.pdf
- Official ABCC page, 2027 edition (dates, venues, format, TBA notices): https://umanitoba.ca/asper/asper-business-case-competition — archived 2025-content version with full schedule: http://web.archive.org/web/20251207164105/https://www.umanitoba.ca/asper/asper-business-case-competition
- Asper case competitions hub (eligibility, past cases, clients): https://umanitoba.ca/asper/student-experience/case-competitions
- ABCC 2026 sponsorship package (tiers, case-sponsor terms): https://umanitoba.ca/asper/sites/asper/files/2026-04/abccsponsorpackage-2026.pdf ; 2025 package: https://umanitoba.ca/asper/sites/asper/files/2024-09/2025-abcc-sponsorship-package.pdf
- Prior guides: ALCC 2023: https://umanitoba.ca/asper/sites/asper/files/2023-02/ALCC23-CompetitionGuide-Final_DIGITAL.pdf ; ABCC 2024: https://umanitoba.ca/asper/sites/asper/files/2024-02/ABCC24-EventGuide-Web-FNL.pdf
- Past case PDFs (e.g., AROW Global 2025 boardroom case, showing deliverable style): https://umanitoba.ca/asper/sites/asper/files/2025-03/abcc-25_case-2.pdf ; Jazz Winnipeg 2026 prepared case: https://umanitoba.ca/asper/sites/asper/files/2026-05/abcc-2026_prepared-case.pdf
- Impact reports (participation statistics): https://umanitoba.ca/asper/sites/asper/files/2024-04/casecomps-impactreport2024-web.pdf ; https://umanitoba.ca/asper/sites/asper/files/2023-05/CaseComps-AnnualReport2023-FNL-Web.pdf

Recaps and results:

- 2026 recap (field, judges, results, social program, case village): https://umtoday.ca/stories/forging-worldwide-relationships-2026-asper-business-case-competition
- 2025 and 2024 recaps via Wayback Machine (news.umanitoba.ca URLs now redirect): “When the classroom becomes a boardroom” (2025) and “Second annual ABCC spotlights Manitoba businesses” (2024)
- Babeș-Bolyai 2026 victory and prize confirmation: https://agerpres.ro/comunicate/2026/02/24/comunicat-de-presa—universitatea-babes-bolyai-din-cluj-napoca–1531333 ; Memorial 2025 win: https://gazette.mun.ca/student-life/high-note/
- HEC Montréal competitions directory entry (selection, language, term): https://www.hec.ca/en/students/campus-life/student-life/university-competitions/competitions-directory/asper-business-case-competition.html

Comparators (for context on sequestration and rubric norms):

- John Molson MBA ICC rules: https://mbacasecomp.com/competition/rules/
- SEC MBA Case Competition rules: https://www.terry.uga.edu/wp-content/uploads/sec-mba-case-competition-rules.pdf

Note: umweb-edit.ad.umanitoba.ca links on the official page return 403 externally; use the umanitoba.ca mirrors above. Historical news.umanitoba.ca articles are recoverable via web.archive.org.